

THIS IS TECHNOLOGY, CULTURE AND SCIENCE WITH A DIFFERENCE, AND THAT DIFFERENCE IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO MAKE MOST NORMAL PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

This month in ALT:

Volcanic lightning, sound trademarks, an interview with the founder of Audible, and all the cool gear that money can buy.



The worst passwords of 2019

Wired has published a list of the 100 worst passwords used in the year, a list periodically interspersed with hilariously relevant memes. Most of the top 10 places are occupied by variations of 12345, while password comes in at number 4. <https://dgit.in/worstpass>

WHAT'S NEW

How to build a more honest internet

The situation that we see with the dissemination of information on the internet was seen more than a 100 years ago, with the introduction of radio. There were new commercial radio stations, non commercial radio stations owned by universities and churches, as well as national radio stations by countries. Over time, radio became one of the most reliable sources for the dissemination of information, as well as a vehicle for public service. The internet has some fundamental problems in its current form, a problem that Shoshana Zuboff, an activist and scholar refers to as "surveillance capitalism". Platforms such as Google and Facebook depend upon the data of their users for



their bread and butter. As a consequence of this model, social media platforms have become addictive, popular and unregulated sources of information, allowing for their weaponization. The bad faith actors can be politically motivated

or propaganda mills of national governments. There are some viable alternative models, including the Wikimedia foundation projects, which are mostly funded by private donors giving small amounts in large numbers.

<https://dgit.in/honestnet>

Crows: Smartest animals apart from primates

In 2002, a group of researchers at Oxford University were spellbound by a crow named Betty that picked up a wire, bent it in the shape of a hook and retrieved a piece of meat from a plastic tube. The crow was celebrated as one with exceptional intelligence, but turns out that all crows make such tools in the wild. It wasn't a one off innovation by Betty, but something that crows had in their nature. Crows hunt



down a specific type of wood to use for these tools, and can find it even when it is hidden beneath leaves. The pliable wood is then made into hooks that are used to retrieve insects from holes. Studies of the

brains of corvids are allowing researchers to better understand intelligence, especially of the non human variety. Crows are smart enough to retain in memory for long periods of time individuals who have harassed them, and they can also use gestures for communication. Studies have shown that crows are both curious and playful, sometimes flexing their mental muscles purely for fun.

<https://dgit.in/smartcrows>



Rewiring brains for maths

Maths may be one of those subjects where intelligent rote learning might actually really complement understanding. Memorising the multiplication tables and operations on fractions, may allow students of mathematics to gain a mastery of the material.

<https://dgit.in/mathbrain>



The Deep Sea

A simple but engaging infographic that allows you to scroll for 10,924 meters to reach the Challenger Deep, the deepest point in the oceans. On the way, you can see the organisms that occupy the oceans at various depths, including colossal squids, hadal amphipods and polar bears.

<https://dgit.in/deepsea>



The problem with reviews

Relying on reviews that point out just one product in each category may not be the best option for everyone. The reviews might not consider, or give less weightage factors such as aesthetics or reliability which might be more important to some people than others.

<https://dgit.in/norev>